Data

The data used for this project cover three domains: income, home values, and retail environments.

Income data come from the Statistics of Income files provided by the IRS. These files provide ZIP code level totals for the number of returns filed in each of six income brackets, as well as for the total dollar amount of income falling into each bracket. These files are provided in a standardized format from 2011 to 2022, with earlier years using varying delineations of the income brackets. For this reason, the years 2011 to 2022 were chose for this study.

Home value data is sourced from the Zillow Home Value Index, which provides an estimate of the value of single-family homes in the 35th to 65th percentile of each ZIP code.

Finally, the retail environment of each ZIP code was assessed using data from the National Neighborhood Data Archive, which collects and publishes data on counts of businesses in different categories based on NAICS codes. The categories of interest in this study thus far are: dollar stores, coffee shops and cafés, delis, and the total number of arts, entertainment and leisure establishments.

The baseline population for this study consists of all ZIP codes in 2011 in each of six core-based statistical areas (CBSAs): Chicago, New York City, Boston, Los Angeles, Washington D.C., and San Francisco. From among these ZIP codes, those designated as gentrifiable in any given year are those with a median income below the fortieth percentile relative to the CBSA. Those identified as gentrifying in any given year are those which were previously identified as gentrifiable in 2011, and exhibit a twenty-five percentile point gap between their median home value and their median income.

Figure 1 shows the share of gentrifiable ZIP codes in each CBSA in 2011.

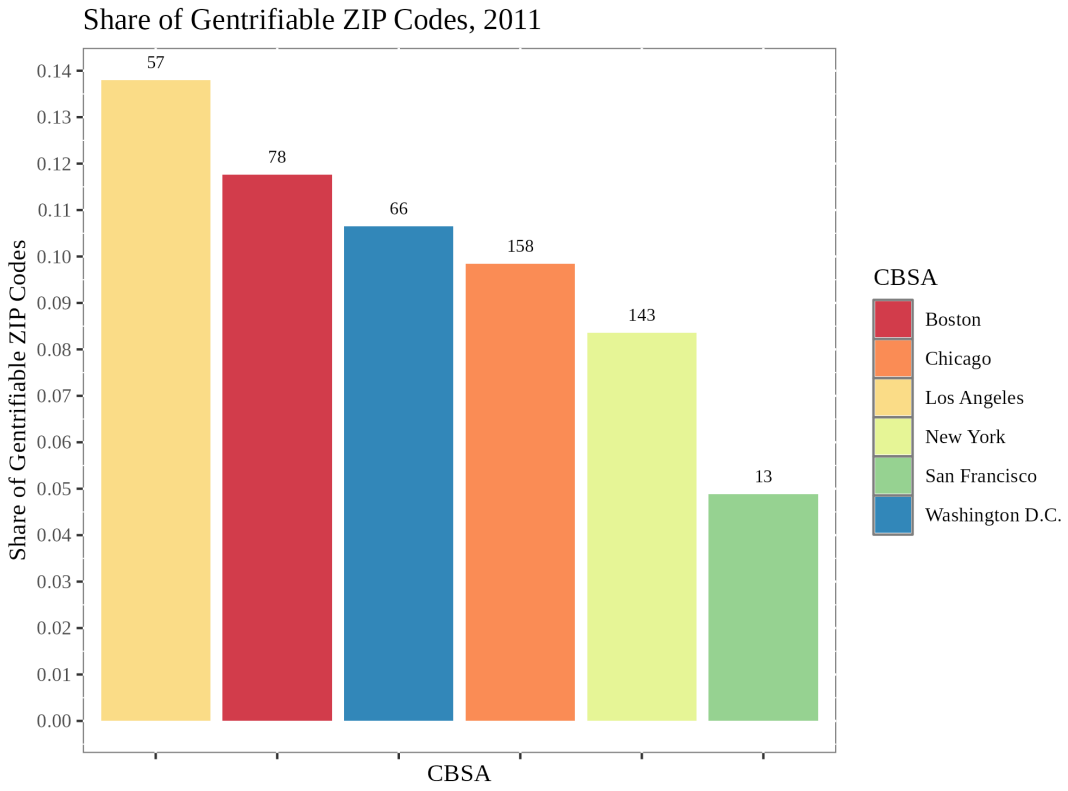
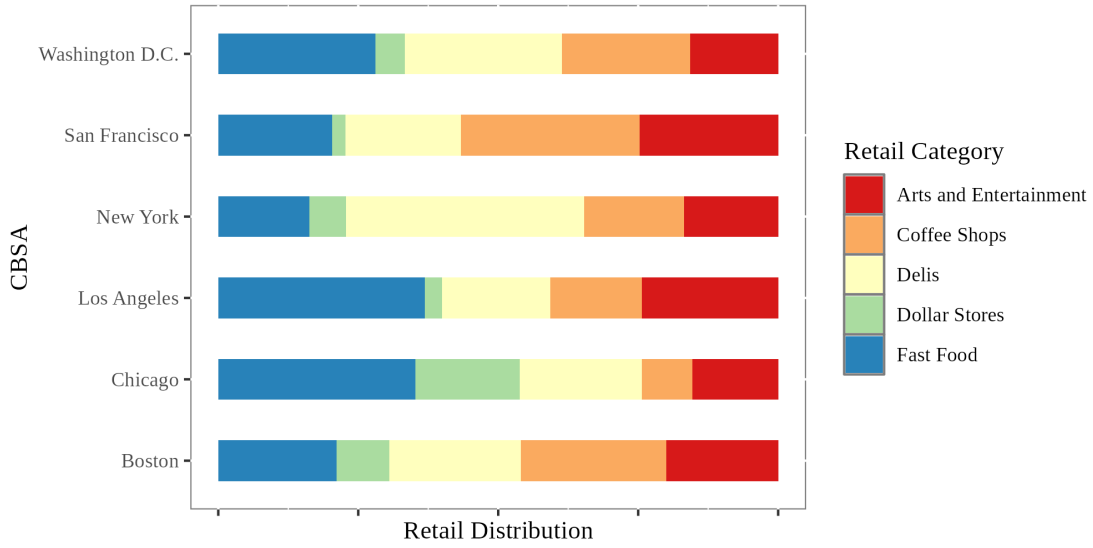


Figure 1: Counts of gentrifiable ZIP codes in each CBSA are displayed above each bar.

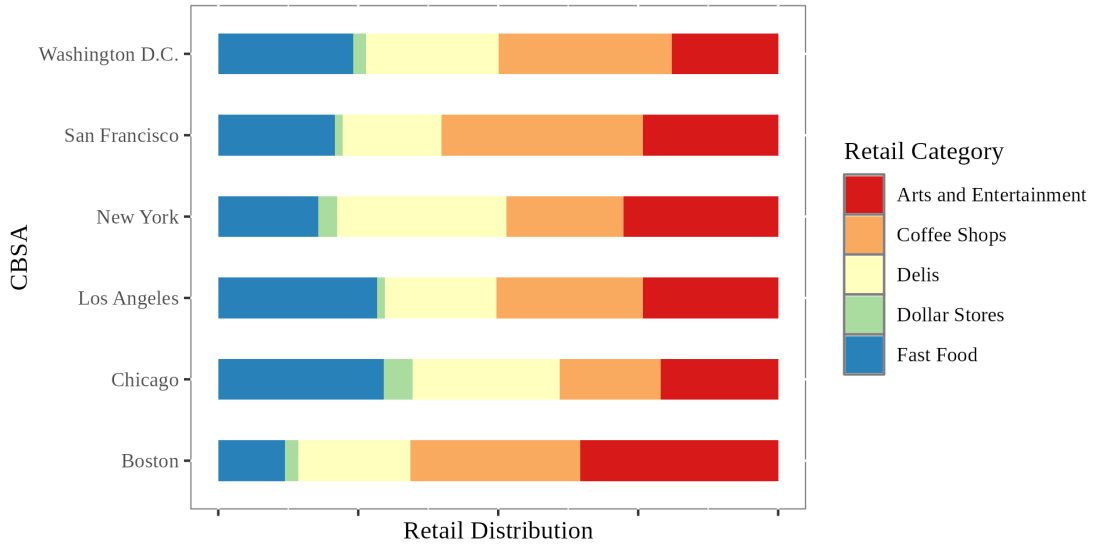
Figures 2 through 4 show the shares of different types of retail establishments in high-income, moderate-income, and low-income ZIP codes in 2011. Here, high-income ZIP codes are defined as those in the top twenty-fifth percentile, low-income as those within the bottom fortieth percentile, and moderate-income as those in between.

Figure 2: Low-Income Retail Distribution by CBSA in 2011



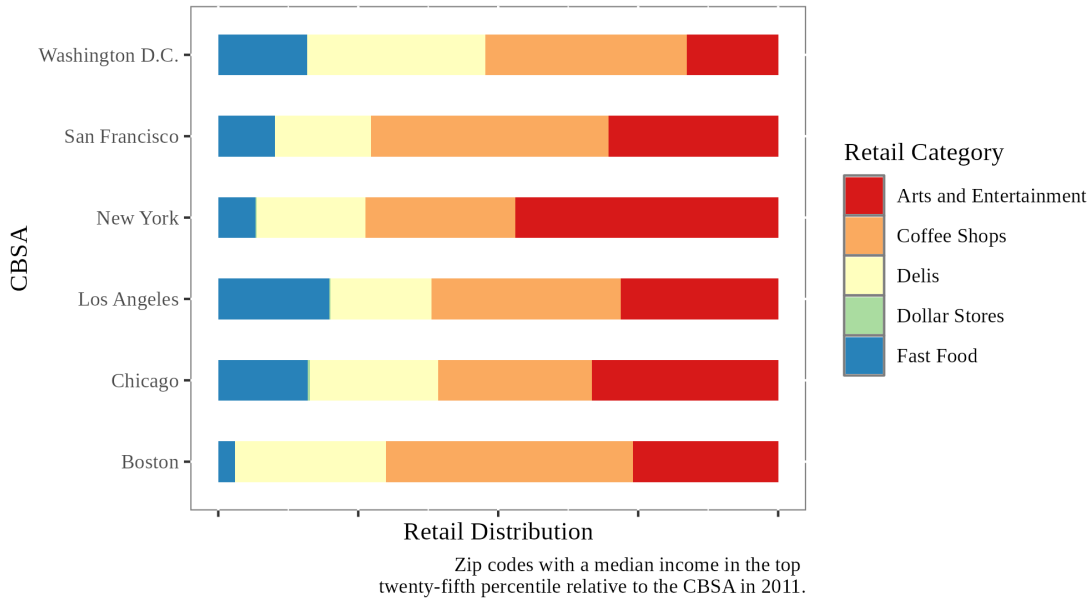
Zip codes with a median income in the bottom fortieth percentile relative to the CBSA in 2011.

Figure 3: Moderate-Income Retail Distribution by CBSA in 2011



Zip codes with a median income below the top twenty-fifth percentile and above the fortieth percentile relative to the CBSA in 2011.

Figure 4: High-Income Retail Distribution by CBSA in 2011



Zip codes with a median income in the top twenty-fifth percentile relative to the CBSA in 2011.